

STUDENT VOICE

THE AMERICAN LANGUAGE CENTER • FES

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Welcome to the New Director: Mr. Christian Sinclair

The ALC Fes/ALIF has undergone a recent change in leadership, with Si David Amster ending his 25 year tenure, and Mr. Christian Sinclair stepping into the role of director. These are new and exciting times for the organization, both locally and generally. Welcome to the new Director of ALC Fes, Mr. Christian Sinclair.

Student Voice: Christian, where are you from personally and professionally?

CS: I'm from the US, born in NY and raised in Pennsylvania. I left the US when I was 19 and stayed abroad for 15 years, studying and working in Scotland, Peru, Spain, Tunisia, Egypt, and Syria. During that time abroad my work was mostly teaching English and training teachers. I returned to the US and got my MA in International Education and began the second phase of my career, which was working in study abroad programs. I was Director of Middle Eastern Studies at SIT Study Abroad in Vermont, where I developed and managed study abroad programs in the Middle East and North Africa for many years. After that I took a position at the University of Arizona's Center for Middle Eastern Studies where I helped create their first study abroad programs in the Middle East. I also took students to Jordan every summer for 8 weeks for an intensive Arabic language and culture program. In addition to my study abroad work, I've also done a lot of teaching. For the past 10 years or so I was teaching two courses in particular. One was about the interplay between music and politics, and the other was intercultural communication. In the field of international education, I think

that courses in intercultural communication are essential for building global awareness.

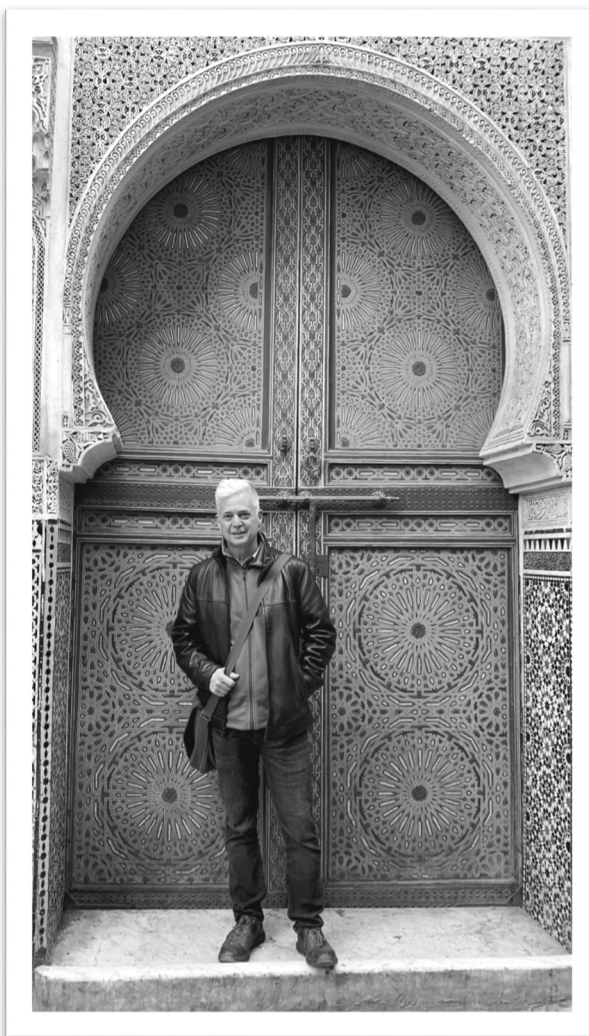
SV: Why Morocco and Fes in particular?

CS: It was the ALC and ALIF that drew

true! It was the perfect opportunity to map all my experience together into one position, to continue educating young minds about the world and its cultures. It's also a great place for intercultural work, sharing experiences, collaborations, and joint ventures. Language can't be taught in a vacuum and it needs a social context; it's experiential, so the culture and community service aspects of ALC Fes/ALIF really spoke to me too. I want to expand on the cultural offerings and community service programming. Arabic language programs are an integral part of my professional experience, and I am really looking forward to working with our ALIF instructors to create new, experiential courses that focus on Fes and the medina in particular.

SV: How would you describe your leadership style and approach?

CS: There's a saying in Japanese, "Ten people, ten colors" meaning, everyone has a different perspective and, whether you agree with them or not, those perspectives are important to that person and have to be taken into account. These perspectives are especially important in a multicultural work environment such as at ALC Fes/ALIF. My leadership style involves a lot of listening and cultural empathy. I like to understand *why* people believe what they believe and to hear them out before making important decisions. Leadership to me is collaborative. I like to be transparent about what I do and what I'm thinking, so creating an atmosphere where everyone feels that their voices are not only heard, but that they are important, is essential to me and how I work.



me here. My career has basically been divided in two distinct parts: working abroad teaching English and training teachers, and then working in the US with students going to MENA to study Arabic language and culture. When I saw the job posting it seemed almost too good to be

Christian Sinclair - continued...

SV: Conflicts and obstacles: what's your philosophy?

CS: "If you can find ways without any obstacles, it probably leads nowhere", is a quote that speaks to me. Personally, I've found that obstacles are opportunities for discussion and learning. We often view obstacles as inherently bad, but if you really look at the process of overcoming them, they are invaluable for personal and professional growth. If you avoid conflict and obstacles, you miss the chance to engage others and learn different perspectives.

SV: What was the most important risk you have taken and why?

CS: When I was 19 I decided to leave the US to study abroad, but not just for a semester. I transferred to a university in Scotland and I moved there. Keep in mind that this was way back in the 80s, before the Internet, so I went blindly into it! But I had wanted to go and live abroad from a young age and I was determined to go, no matter what. This led to my 15-year adventure overseas and to my career in international education.

SV: What's your proudest achievement?

CS: When I worked for SIT Study Abroad and was looking for new program ideas, I decided that Oman would be a good destination for Arabic study and in 2003 I created the very first study abroad program in that country. It was quite a challenge working with the various government ministries there and convincing them that we should be allowed to set up an office in Muscat and bring American students there to study. Our first cohort had only three students, but since then Oman has become a very popular country for students studying Arabic abroad.

SV: What is your biggest regret, or one decision you wish you hadn't made?

CS: Life is full of bad decisions and regrets, but I look at them as learning experiences. I'll give you one example. Many years ago when living in Syria I started writing a novel. It's a murder mystery set in Damascus back in the 1960s. I wrote a couple hundred pages and when I moved back to the US I packed all the pages and notes up in a box and forgot about it. I regret never

SV: What are your hobbies & interests outside of work?

CS: I try to keep busy as much as possible when I'm not at work. I like cooking, reading, bike riding, hiking, and music. I brought my bicycle here to Fes, but I haven't had a chance yet to get out and ride. I'd really like to find others who cycle who can show me the best places to go. The same goes for hiking. I'm looking forward to exploring all that Morocco has to offer!



SV: What's your favorite book?

CS: My favorites are by Somerset Maugham: *Of Human Bondage*, *Moon and Sixpence*, and *The Razor's Edge*. They all discuss ideas of conventional existence vs. creative or personal fulfillment and our struggle deciding which is the right path. Rejecting the status quo is not without pitfalls, but I love the way



All photo credits: Christian Sinclair

finishing it, but I still have that box and brought it here with me. Maybe I'll sort through it all and finish it here in Fes. Who knows!

SV: Who inspires you?

CS: Musicians. Those who use their work to discuss social issues inspire me immensely. Meriam Makeba from South Africa, Fela Kuti from Nigeria, and Andrea Echeverri from Colombia, spring to mind. Lately I've been listening to "Massar Egbari" from Egypt. They are a rock band, but combine traditional Middle Eastern sounds with blues and jazz too. Their music challenges the status quo. And it's so much more interesting than your run-of-the-mill pop music.

they portray societal expectations and social constraints against our personal struggle to do what calls us. I read those books for the first time in my late teens and I have re-read them many many times since.

Christian, on behalf of all the staff at the ALC Fes/ALIF, I would like to extend a big *Marhabek* to you and we hope Fes treats you well for this exciting new chapter!



TRAVELLING SOLO

Travelling solo is much better than going on tour. Actually, travelling alone has many benefits, which make you stronger and more independent in your own decisions and choices. As you experience new adventures and deal with problems, as a consequence you develop new skills that help you a lot in the different fields of common life. Travelling solo is the best way to confront your thoughts, to be at peace with yourself, and to find your authentic self: follow where your spirit leads you! All of the known explorers chose to go on their own adventures, and they are successful people because of the extreme experience they had and the useful lessons they took away.

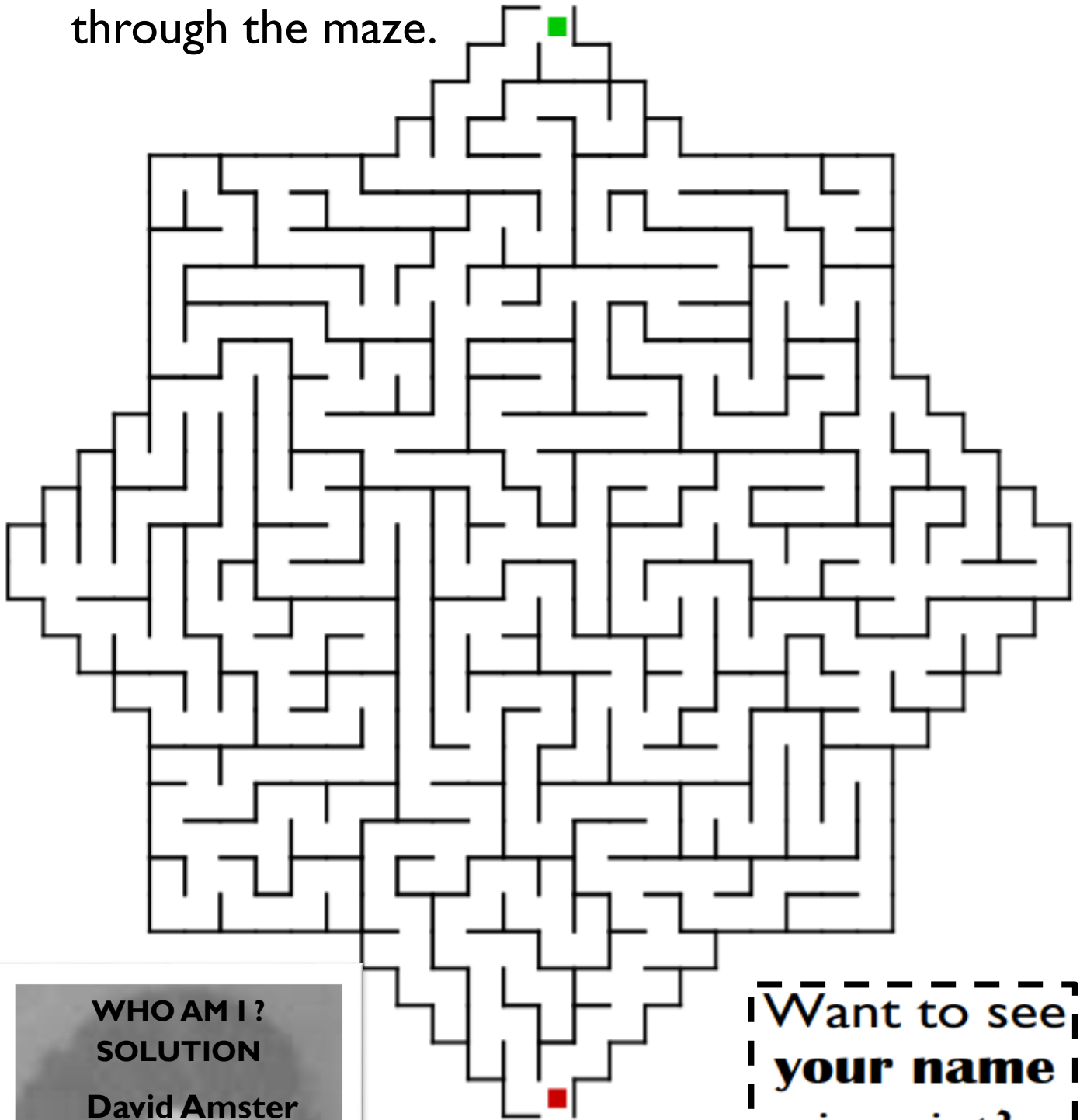


If you start thinking of all the downsides of going alone on a trip you will become scared of the idea. However, we humans need to go out of our comfort zones and take advantage of travelling alone because it's the only way to improve and find the best version of yourself.

Mouad El Markhi
Advanced 3

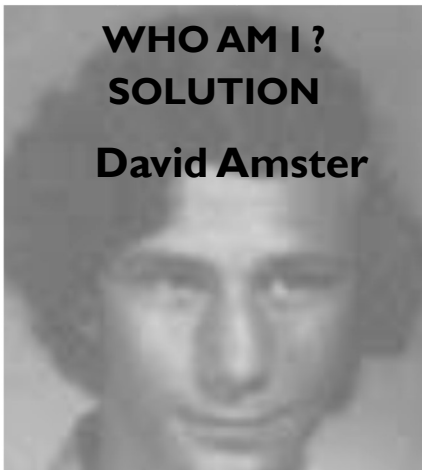
Submitting Teacher - Heather Harris.

Trace your way from top to bottom
through the maze.



WHO AM I?
SOLUTION

David Amster



Want to see
your name
in print?



alcstudentvoice@gmail.com